

Pressing, Dragging, & Dropping

Pressing

Pressing the mouse button and holding it down is called, logically enough, pressing. As with clicking, you don't speak of pressing the mouse button; you speak instead of pressing the object you're pointing to.

Pressing a menu title in the menu bar pulls down (displays) the menu. If you're following along in the Finder, try it with the File menu. Pressing, alone, is useful to see what's on a menu without actually selecting an item. Release the button to remove the menu from the screen.

Dragging

To drag an object, continue to hold down the mouse button while moving the mouse. You'll use the drag technique with icons (try dragging the System Disk icon around) and pull-down menus. For now it may not seem too useful to drag icons around on the Desktop, but that's how you copy files from one disk to another (more on that later).

Sometimes you'll be required to "drag a rectangle." You use this technique in the Finder to select a group of icons that are close together on the screen, and to draw boxes in paint programs. To drag a rectangle, you press the mouse at one corner of the rectangle you want to define (it doesn't matter which corner you start with, though most people start with the upper left corner out of habit) and drag it to the corner *diagonally opposite* the corner you started from (the lower right corner in our example). Try dragging a rectangle around some of the icons on the Finder screen if you're following along.

Dropping

Dropping is the action that occurs when you release the mouse button after a drag. (Sometimes this is simply called releasing, too—you generally "release" menus.) When you're dragging an icon, you'll probably want to drop it eventually. It's natural to speak of dropping it back onto the desktop, or into a folder, or into the trash.

Other Mouse Maneuvers

Double-Clicking

Double-clicking is two quick clicks of the mouse with very little delay between the two clicks. The computer registers these two clicks as one event. In the Finder, double-clicking an icon opens it (a useful shortcut for selecting Open from the File menu); in most word processors, double-clicking a word selects that word (remember, single-clicking in a document just moves the insertion point). Occasionally you'll even be called upon to perform *triple*-clicking.